Learn from ancient times to present moments

What did Attila the Hun have to say to us?



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Years ago, I read the Leadership Secrets of Attila the Hun, he was one of those inspiring leaders in history. But recently, I once more went through the book with an eye to discover his secrets from a human resources point of view.

I have noticed that history teaches so many aspects of human resources management, but first and foremost is that we have to read, re-read, and keep reading. As Alvin Toffler once said, "The illiterate of the 21st century will not be those who cannot read and write, but those who cannot learn, unlearn and relearn."

Generally speaking, HRM has mainly four major operations – staffing, performance management, rewards, and training and development – that can be directly related back to the great and ancient legend of Attila's leadership wisdom and organisation of his tribes. Here's what we can learn from him …

1. Staffing

The aim of a staffing system within HRM is to attract and acquire good calibre people based on organisational needs and future aspirations. Thus, staffing activities are increasingly important components of HR systems. And, it is argued that, if organisations are to be effective, they have to have the required quality and quantity of people who are properly utilised. To the above objective, organisations have to properly accomplish staffing activities. Thus, staffing is an important function of HRM, that is, concerned with obtaining the proper kind (quality) and number (quantity) of human resources necessary to accomplish organisational goals.

Similar to the above statement, Attila was going to need and maintain to form a group of chief leaders that could make his world dominance aspirations into a tremendous reality. They had to possess 16 praiseworthy qualities: loyalty, courage, desire, emotional stamina, physical stamina, empathy, decisiveness, anticipation, timing, competitiveness, self-confidence, accountability, responsibility, credibility, tenacity, dependability, and stewardship. His selection process was based primarily on skill, and not of royal descent.

He believed that the individual who possessed the desire to be in charge could develop and master the sixteen qualities. In line with the definition of a human resource staffing system, he was forming his workers and chieftains around an "internal oriented staffing system" that was also focused around the potential abilities of an individual.

2. Performance Management

Performance is defined and understood as achievement of the organisation in relation with its set goals and objectives. It includes outcomes achieved, or accomplished through contribution of individuals or teams to the organisation's strategic goals. The term "performance" encompasses economic as well as behavioural outcomes.

In HRM, Performance Management is the process of defining clear objectives and targets for individuals and teams, and the regular review of actual achievement and eventual rewarding for target achievement. The process should ensure that individual and team effort support the organisational objectives and that key stakeholder expectations are realised by focusing on key value drivers.

Attila ensured that his staff were following certain performance levels before being granted positions or promotion among the chieftain leaders. He lists numerous criteria that would fit today's standards of a well-defined performance/ dimension and behavioural rating tool. Though there are two criteria for an accurate assessment of performance, one additionally being a point-scale, Attila's undeniable achievements proved his defined behavioural assessment alone was enough to implement great leadership into the Hun's tribes.

He also determined a list of responsibilities, or

goals, a chieftain had to meet prior to being a leader to the Hun warriors. He did not evaluate his people on results alone, rather in large regard to how they adhered to custom, how they behaved, and how they influenced their subordinate Huns. They were expected to follow the set performance, and rewards and punishment system. Chieftains were instructed to treat their subordinates in a fair and just manner, which could also be looked at as procedural justice. They were expected to role model the morale and discipline of Attila, encourage motivation and positivity among their subordinates and supervisors, show complete commitment to the mission, train their fellow Huns, and make sure they were rightfully meeting the expectations established.

3. Reward System

Rewards are the benefits that arise from performing a task, rendering a service or discharging a responsibility, in the form of financial and nonfinancial benefits, and it is designed to obtain and keep the type of people the organisation needs and encourage behaviour which will contribute directly to the achievement of organisational goals or services.

According to literature, rewards are often categorised into two broad areas, namely extrinsic rewards and intrinsic rewards. Extrinsic rewards are usually financial or tangible rewards, which include pay, promotion, interpersonal rewards, bonuses and benefits. Intrinsic rewards are those which are non-cash rewards or do not have any physical existence - for example, employee recognition, acknowledgement, professional growth, authority to immediate tasks, respect and appreciation.

Attila issued fundamental rewards in the form of gained respect to one's labours and achievements, or by granting one greater responsibility, or higher training. The goal of "paying deference" is to give recognition to the abilities and potentials of subordinates.

He also instructed his leaders to treat their subordinates with respect so they may be "guided, developed, and rewarded for their performance". Punishment was only to be issued if all other disciplinary action proved unsuccessful. Attila's extrinsic rewards to his warriors and chieftains was in the form of booty rations (a form of wage or treasure). However, Attila had rules on how this booty was to be awarded. If a Hun did a prominent task, his booty rewards were increased, if he accomplished a minor task his booty rewards were met with equal size.

Like the wage system of today, the chieftains who possessed more experience and responsibility, were also issued larger amounts of pay than their subordinates. Promotion came with certain conditions, particularly for a chieftain whose performance failed to meet standards; if he was purposely taken out of his position, his leading subordinate was ordered not to replace him. It was thought that an under-performing chieftain, created disappointing subordinates as well. Under this rule, few unintentional errors could have occurred for the subordinates; a contrast error, such as being rated for their performance in contrast to their chieftain, or a severity error, in which the entire group was rated negatively, was based on the poor performance level of the chieftain.

4. Training and Development

Training and Development in organisations play a significant role in their effectiveness and to the experiences of people at work. All organisations

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Teachable skills, also defined by HR as learner-centered, were for the Huns warriors, in which they were taught by other leaders with the opportunity of practising and applying to gain procedural knowledge. Leaders and warriors of the Huns were not expected to develop every necessary characteristic immediately and/or master them rapidly. These qualities were assumed to require (and most likely did require) years of training and development if they wanted to become highly skilled chieftains. No matter their aptitude level, Attila expected his warriors and chieftains to continually devote time to the advancement of themselves.

> The more you know about the past, the better prepared you are for the future.
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requirement and invest effort and other resources in training and development. Such activities are normally initiated by orientation for the newcomers on the culture, policies and procedures and socialising them with the existing members in order to reduce anxiety level.

The orientation process of an outsider coming into the Hun's tribe involved first learning the customs, rituals and traditions of its culture. The outsiders were not expected to shed their complete individuality, but they were expected to honour the customs and emulate them within and outside of the tribe. The assessment phase between the Huns and chieftains were treated differently. The chieftains were taught by learnable skills, or in human resources terms, through learning team-centered skills, in which they acquired knowledge through their own leadership processes. Teachable skills, also defined by HR as learner-centered, were for the Huns warriors, in which they were taught by other leaders with the opportunity of practising and applying to gain procedural knowledge. Leaders and warriors of the Huns were not expected to develop every necessary characteristic immediately and/or master them rapidly. These qualities were assumed to require (and most likely did require) years of training and development if they wanted to become highly skilled chieftains. No matter their aptitude level, Attila expected his warriors and chieftains to continually devote time to the advancement of themselves.

Attila had a set standard of basic skills he required. If a Hun wanted to become a part of their army of warriors, Attila mandated they learn how to shoot a bow and arrow, while riding on horseback. If these warriors strongly displayed the 16 qualities, their training could move in a leadership direction. To better assess the Hun's ability in becoming a leader, Attila listed several motives a Hun warrior needed to possess beforehand. This same principle applies when an employee is determining the training needs of his/her employees. Above all, Attila stated that they must have an inner desire to lead.

From this, arose a need to acquire the endurance to complete allotted tasks of their warriors, to retain over zealousness with patient planning, the ability to endure trials and obstacles, streamline difficult tasks, show gratitude to their subordinates and superiors, be able to accept flaws and have a desire to learn from and overcome them. Under these criteria a fellow chieftain or Attila, would then move the warrior into leadership development.

Conclusion

Once again, history is teaching us tremendous lessons. If you are intrigued by our past and want to learn how it will shape our future, you should consider reading about history. History is a multifaceted discipline that will increase your awareness and moral understanding of the world we live in.

You'll gain a range of transferable skills and ideas. What's more, the knowledge acquired through history is relevant in a wide range of situations and can lead to diverse success. ■

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